

[nature](#) > [career column](#) > article

CAREER COLUMN | 11 February 2026

Four ways I ensured my research brought about real-world change

After realizing that her work wasn't reaching its target audience, marketing researcher Lan Nguyen Chaplin decided to take action.

By [Lan Nguyen Chaplin](#)

You have full access to this article via **University of the Andes**.



Sharing research findings through non-academic outlets can be rewarding and allow them to reach a wide audience. Credit: Getty

As a marketing academic specializing in children’s consumer behaviour, I’ve always strived for my next journal publication and to earn the respect of my peers. But beneath it all, one question has often nagged at me: who is reading my work?

My research – much of it fusing insights from child development and consumer psychology – was trapped inside academic silos and behind paywalls, out of sight of the educators, parents and policymakers who needed it.

The frustration had nothing to do with failing to get my work published in top journals; while I was building my career as an assistant professor, moving from the University of Illinois Urbana–Champaign to the University of Arizona in

Tucson, and again to Villanova University in Pennsylvania, I published papers in all of the right places. But I felt as if I was failing to keep pace with the real-life questions that educators and families have every day about the impact of marketing on children's well-being.

RELATED



Before making a career move, try an experiment

The long delays between submitting a manuscript and eventually seeing it in print had also taken much of the joy out of research for me. In one of my projects, for example, I examined the happiness that children derive from experiences, such as going to see a film or playing sports, compared with the happiness that they derive from owning material goods – and how these tendencies change with age. That paper went

through two different journals and three editorial teams before it saw the light of day, eight years after it was initially submitted.

I started my career in 2003, before digital publishing became standard practice. My early journal articles often took months to appear in print after acceptance. Because marketing as a field is fast-paced – and because children are especially vulnerable to evolving marketing messages – I recognized a need to share my research findings more promptly, effectively and broadly than journal publications alone allowed.

From around 2007, I took four steps to ensure that my research reached a wider audience quickly and had a meaningful impact.

Reflecting on my role as an academic

The first step was perhaps the most difficult: I started going to therapy to come to terms with my growing frustration and burnout from following the conventional academic path.

I struggled with not feeling happy despite having made a strong start to my academic career, and feeling empty even though I had earned the respect and support of my peers. I constantly questioned my purpose as a researcher.

RELATED



Tips and tricks to plan your career in science

Therapy helped me to acknowledge that I was putting too much pressure on myself to stick to the conventional publishing grind.

My therapist proposed that I write a reflective letter from the perspective of my future self, praising what I had already achieved, as well as suggesting theoretical actions that I could take to help accomplish my goals. This allowed me to better appreciate the specific actions that I had already taken to build a career that truly made me happy. As I wrote the letter, I detailed the ways that I had constructed a career defined by my own ambitions and interests, rather than by others' expectations and ideals.

In the letter, I encouraged myself to take risks, to let go of outdated graduate-school definitions of success and to continuously seek out opportunities that inspired and energized me. Ultimately, this gave me the ability to imagine a different, more-rewarding way forwards.

Armed with this fresh perspective, I took the next step towards sharing my work broadly. In 2009, about four years after I had published my first research paper in the *Journal of Consumer Research*, I became more intentional about

publishing in journals that aren't focused solely on consumer marketing research.

Searching for other outlets

I began submitting papers to journals that publish articles on topics outside my core academic focus, ones that attract a wider readership of people interested in research on children's happiness and their choices, such as the *Journal of Happiness Studies*¹, *Child Development*² and *Psychological Science*³. I also worked with my university's media-relations team to write both non-technical summaries and press releases whenever I published work, and actively sought expertise on communicating with journalists. Despite being nervous about talking to the media, I made it a priority to respond to every interview or information request that I received and, in doing so, managed to reach a non-academic audience.

RELATED



Small, affordable undergraduate research programmes changed my career and strengthen US science. Why cut them?

This approach brought my research into the pages of [*Fortune*](#), [*Forbes*](#) and [*The New York Times*](#). Here, the public – including families, educators and business leaders – could read about my practical interventions, such as encouraging children to keep a gratitude journal as a way to combat the increase in materialism that has been observed in younger generations.

I'd advise anyone who is looking to maximize their research's impact to connect with people in their university's media-relations team. E-mail them to request a meeting to share your work (and why it matters).

In the meeting, express your interest in writing accessible summaries and press releases for broader audiences, and ask about training opportunities to improve your public-engagement skills. When you publish an article, work with the media-relations team to create easy-to-understand summaries and stay responsive to media enquiries. This guidance can help your research to inspire change well beyond academia.

Reaching a broader audience

Engaging with audiences beyond academia proved to be highly rewarding, motivating me to publish more articles that would reach and resonate with a broader audience, focusing not only on my research, but also on my experience of working in academia.

For the past five years, I've openly discussed career challenges that are rarely addressed, such as [how to handle embarrassing moments at work](#), [how to cope with teaching evaluations](#) that shake your confidence and [how to overcome a considerable career setback](#).

Taking my research into the local community

The last step that I took to make me feel happier in my career and like I was contributing to the world was introducing my expertise in consumer psychology and marketing research to my local community. I joined leadership groups for two non-profit organizations: [Cradles to Crayons](#) and [Communities in Schools of Chicago](#), which focus on providing children with household necessities and connecting them to support programmes as needed. I helped these organizations by sharing my expertise in branding and children's development, to ensure that children receive the resources they need to support their well-being and achieve educational success.

Reaching a wider audience has taught me lessons about what truly matters in an academic life. Letting go of the pressure to chase only the most elite journals in my specific field of study opened my eyes to how much there is to learn from sharing ideas with people both outside my field and outside academia entirely.

This hasn't diminished my academic standing; instead, it has boosted my connections with my peers, industry leaders and the communities that my work supports.

doi: <https://doi-org.ezproxy.uniandes.edu.co/10.1038/d41586-025-03490-x>

This is an article from the Nature Careers Community, a place for Nature readers to share their professional experiences and advice. [Guest posts are encouraged.](#)

[Subscribe to Nature Briefing: Careers, an unmissable free weekly round-up of help and advice for working scientists.](#)

References

1. Chaplin, L. N. *J. Happiness Stud.* **10**, 541–562 (2009).

2. Chaplin, L. N. & Norton, M. I. *Child Dev.* **86**, 651–658 (2015).

3. Gasiorowska, A., Chaplin, L. N., Zaleskiewicz, T., Wygrab, S. & Vohs, K. D. *Psychol. Sci.* **27**, 331–344 (2016).
-

COMPETING INTERESTS

The author declares no competing interests.

Latest on:

[Education](#)

[Media](#)

[Publishing](#)

How should I respond to race-based exclusion in my lab?

CAREER FEATURE |

23 JUN 26

Gen Z scepticism towards AI is a wake-up call – universities must take it seriously

WORLD VIEW | 10 JUN 26

AI technology must serve human cognitive development, not the other way around

CORRESPONDENCE |

09 JUN 26

Nature (*Nature*) | ISSN [1476-4687](#) (online) | ISSN [0028-0836](#) (print)